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Rufus Reid

Rufus Reid has made his mark in the jazz world as a bassist, educator and composer. His lengthy list of musical associates include the Thad Jones/Mel Lewis Orchestra, Dexter Gordon and Eddie Harris, and Rufus now leads his own "Out Front" Trio. He created the Jazz Studies program at William Paterson University with Dr. Martin Krivin, and authored The Evolving Bassist *method book and DVD.*

Rufus was interviewed in Atlanta, GA, on January 4, 2013, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We're at the JazzEd Conference in Atlanta 2013, and I'm happy to have Rufus Reid with me today. And I'm going to call you a bassist/composer/educator.

RR: Okay.

MR: Now is that the order in which you do business today?

RR: I am now. The composing part wasn't there for most of my career, that most people know me about. The education has been a big part of, and continues to be, although I'm not teaching regularly anymore at a university. But it was a bassist/educator, and it took me a while before I even wanted to put the composer part to it. And it's still hard for me, but I realize now that — I guess now at least ten years I've been trying to do more extensive compositions in the last fifteen years, but the last ten years things have really just kind of exploded a little bit in terms of how my music has resonated with other people, and I've been getting a lot of my music performed. And that's a composer's nightmare, of hoping that someone will at least read it, much less perform it, or even record it. I mean that's — so now I can feel that I can put, if I could actually have two colors of where you could still read them, you know, the education and composition, you could see both of them but they're on top of each other, as opposed to side by side. And eventually — but it's kind of nice to put bassist and composer and educator. But the composition and education was doing this for a long time, you know, was kind of moving back and forth. But I really, in essence all three have to be there.

MR: I've often wondered about — I do some writing myself, and I wonder sometimes about, let's suppose I had a decent amount of money to spend, and I was going to commission you to write something. Is it easier for you if you have no guidelines, or if you have some guidelines?

RR: Very good question. I have to say right now I would prefer none. However, that means you have to accept whatever you get. Now generally someone says well this is the ensemble that I want. But they don't tell you what to write. That's okay. And I've learned to arrange, and that's different too. But you know, someone gave me a choice, and I have

been involved with this BMI Composer's Workshop with Manny Albam and Jim McNeeley. Brookmeyer started it but I got a chance to be around all of those guys. And so they're really composers, I mean serious composers. But Manny was like a composer, but he was really like, we used to call him the "half hour of the incredible arrangers." He could come up, in a half hour, he would have an arrangement that would just sound great. And that's a skill, a true skill. But my very — yeah I guess it was my first real commission that came to me not through the BMI program, an Air Force — I wrote something for an Air Force Band in Europe. And he says, "Well I'd like you to write something for the band, and you can either arrange something or you can write something." And I was right in the middle of the Composer's Workshop and I said "well I'd better try to write something." He says, "Well great, but could you write something for a tenor and bass duo, kind of reminiscent of John Coltrane and Paul Chambers." And it was like okay. I mean he kind of put some handcuffs on.

MR: I would say.

RR: Right away. But I said okay. I took the challenge with that, and I still came up with something that I still utilize myself now.

MR: As a duo?

RR: No, as a big band.

MR: Oh, I see, that featured those instruments.

RR: Yeah. He says I have this tenor player in the band and I want to feature him on it and we've got a good bass player da, da, da, da. And when he first said that — but, I'm a novice out here. So I was just happy someone was asking me to do anything. So I said, "Well okay, I'll take that challenge." And it has turned out, it turned out that he really liked it, and it dovetailed into something else that was totally — I've recorded it with my trio, I've recorded it — in fact the Air Force Band actually recorded it, flew me down to Texas and we recorded it. So I mean I said "wow — what would have happened if I'd just said no, I don't want to do that." So other things — I don't know. Something told me you've got to do this. And it turned out really well.

MR: Do you go to the piano first, the bass first, neither, just think?

RR: All of the above so to speak. Like this particular piece was called "Come Out and Play." I don't have perfect pitch and so I was on the airplane and I just started writing rhythms with a drummer. I keep a drummer and a guitar player and a piano player in my head all the time. So if it swings, if it just feels good to me, so I just started writing page after page of just rhythms and things. And I'd been working on this tone row at home, and fooling around with it and found a couple that I really liked. And then I began to take some of those notes and put them on these rhythms and that's how the piece got born. And then of course I started editing and kind of completely ignoring the rules of the row

— I mean not totally — but I began and I said well maybe I shouldn't do that. And then someone told me, he says, "It's your piece, you can do anything you want with it."

MR: It sounds good, that's the bottom line, isn't it?

RR: So that's how that piece came about. And it was thrilling. Then I put harmony to it after that. So to answer your question, I actually tend to go to the piano first. I will confirm, if it feels good on the bass then I know I'm in the right direction with it. I do try to play it on the bass just to see — 'cause I'm not a pianist. I can play the piano — and so I tend to confirm what I think will work with the bass.

MR: And this, be specific, what you were describing for the Air Force Band, can I assume you were doing that with pen and paper?

RR: Yes. Pencil and paper. A big eraser.

MR: I am also going to assume then, that you had not heard it, sort of electronically, before they performed it, or before they read it.

RR: Well actually I did. However, I still didn't know what it really sounds like, because what the computer stuff has helped at least hopefully got rid of a lot of the editing of misspelled notes or accidentals and stuff like that. But when I heard it the first time I said wow. It was kind of amazing.

MR: It was a good wow then.

RR: Yeah. It was a good wow. Well the thing is, it was the first time that I actually had to finish something and put it in an envelope and mail it off to Germany. And this is what I learned in the workshop is that now, because you try to be articulate enough with the score and all the dynamics and everything that you want it to be so that you don't have to be there and say, "Well I really mean this." And to me that's still one of the more difficult things, to be that articulate. Because you're going to have different interpretations or something, but they all should, if it's really cared for that way, that you're probably going to get a really high percentage of close to where you think. But that was frightening because I put it in the mail so I had to wait for the time that I thought it actually arrived, and then I waited for another time for him to call me after they'd rehearsed it, and so I wasn't sure, wow, did he like it?

MR: No news is not necessarily good news.

RR: No. Yes. But it was really good to hear from him. There were some errors, but they liked it. And it was really challenging because it wasn't the typical instrumentation. So I couldn't just go on automatic pilot with the stuff and that was great.

MR: Well this could be a hard question, but how do you price your work?

RR: That is difficult. Because like I say, I am a novice so I really feel I can't do it. Because I'm slow. It takes me time. Although if they give me a timeline, that helps. Because now I say well this is a chunk of time in order for me to do this. I ask some friends, and I look

at — sometimes I look at some published charts and how much they are charging for the chart itself, and then I say well okay — and I may ask them what kind of budget that you have, and we can discuss it. Because I think it's just like my performing. Everything's on sliding scale as far as I'm concerned. And here again I realize they're asking me now to write something and I would like to be paid as much money as I can possibly get paid. However, I think there is a place and a time where I've come now where if someone's going to ask me I may have a figure, let's start here as a base. And if you can give me more, great. And if it's too much let's talk about it. Whatever. But I don't even discuss that until — I mean it's not going to change what I'm going to write basically. I mean it's like playing. I'm not going to play any less if I'm going to play for ten people or ten thousand people. I'm not going to play different. I can't. I don't know how to play less — and just do it like it should be done. I mean I've been blessed with people who just play, they play good all the time. Milt Hinton and I were in a room, in my house, and we could have played for ten thousand people and it would have been incredible. But it was just he and I. And he was playing like — it was amazing. So I mean, because when you play, I don't know how to dilute what I play. I just play what I play. People wait 'till the stage for the concert to give it all up. Slide Hampton — I got a chance to play with him and the rehearsal was so unbelievable it just gave you an idea of what that concert was going to be like, and so I've learned to just give it up, just play. And that's all I really know.

MR: I've been very fortunate to get to know a few of those people, like Milt Hinton. Do you have words to describe what it was like to be around him and that generation of players?

RR: Wow. It was very fulfilling to be around him, in every way. I mean he seemed to satisfy everything you were wondering about, it was not a mystery, it was just there. He had an aura about him that was so positive, and everything was positive. I never saw him — I was around him a lot. We used to go visit him in his home when he was declining. But he still was amazing. But when he was on, you know, earlier in years he was playing, it was a true, it was just honest stuff. He wasn't trying to show off, he just did what he did. But you were saying whoa. Then you said, "Do you know how old he is?" Yeah, and he played better — but he loved to play the bass. If you played bass, even if you just bought your bass that day, you were part of the family. And he was that kind of person. But when I first met him, it was like I'd known him for years. It was with the New York Bass Choir in New York and I got a chance to go to Bill Lee's house over in Brooklyn at ten o'clock in the morning on a Saturday, and Milt was there, and it was incredible. Richard Davis and Bill Lee and Lyle Atkinson. Ron Carter didn't come that day but it was incredible. And then they finished. And I didn't know where I was. I knew I was in Brooklyn but I didn't know where I was. And I was staying in Manhattan in a hotel. So I said, "Can anybody show me how to get to the subway?" I found my way there and Milt

said, "Well I'm going now, come on with me." And we walked, and I had to walk faster to keep up with him. And that's how our relationship, from that day, it was perfect. He was really, really, really wonderful.

MR: That's great. I saw a thing that you said which really caught my eye. And it went something like, "Assume there's nobody else, tell students to play as if there's no one else in the rhythm section." And the first time I went like "wow." Some people would say, like what do you mean, the rhythm section has to be one, everybody has to be together. But then you went on to explain it. I wish you would explain it again, because I found it really very interesting.

RR: Well bass players, I think we have, I assume you're the only harmonic and rhythmic substance that there is. In other words, don't — if the piano player's not there, does that mean you can't play? If the drummer's not there, does that mean you can't play with good time? So you don't really need them. And they don't need you either. If they play with good time and good sense of harmony and everything, that's how solo pianists can — I mean the piano is an orchestra, so I mean they can do a lot more things obviously, than with the bass. But the bass can actually do something alone and make people believe they're hearing harmony if they sculpt and craft their bass lines. And they can — I call the bassist — we have to be illusionists, a magician. We have to make people hear and see things that aren't there, and not miss them. Now that's quite a chore, and yet it's not as difficult as one might think. But I mean Bach would have been a fantastic jazz musician. Because he was improvising. But let's say the Bach Cello Suites. There's no harmony. There's no chords. I mean once in a while you might have some fifths and stuff like this, but it's about placement and resolution, and how he connects things. And you hear harmony everywhere. And so rhythm changes has a sound, blues has a sound, "My One and Only Love" has a sound. Any song has its own sound. And if you can get that sound, not play the changes — people play the changes, it's the formula that kind of gets you into it. And I learned — I didn't know what all the hieroglyphics of sharp fives and plus zeros — that was hieroglyphics to me. I knew the big letters, but it had a sound. And my ears said, "Eww that didn't sound right," so I moved my hand to another note. And it was generally a half-step above or below. And that's how I edited myself. And eventually I learned why I liked the sound. And now I can put something on this sound, a symbol, and now I know.

MR: You sort of played it first by trial and error, then learned why it sounded good?

RR: Right. And then tried to be consistent with that. Because I had a lot of great on-the-job training as a bassist. I listened to a lot of records and I would sing along with them and play, but I didn't know harmony for a long time. No one told me when I was younger, I used to play the trumpet so I was in the Air Force Band as a trumpet player and I

basically kind of taught myself the bass. But no one told me that I really should understand harmony and maybe get a little friendly with the piano at that time.

[Pause]

MR: Was this in Chicago?

RR: No. Montgomery, Alabama. I joined the — I was in the Air Force. I was going to get drafted, and someone says well if you pass the audition for the Air Force Band, you'll automatically get in the band if you pass, but in the Air Force there's no guarantees that I was going to get a chance — it was either trumpet or rifle or something. So none of that. But I taught myself those things. But no one told me about how important piano was, like the kids today now. And it was a revelation of learning the harmony. I mean I heard things but I didn't know, it didn't connect for a long time. But now, when it did — because I got into things because I had good ears. I got into places that I shouldn't have been able to hang. But I realized, hmmm, I didn't know that. But I was going to let them know that I finally figured it out. I got there, because I began to play in situations that people thought I knew more than I knew. But eventually I got into it and I said, oh man, I've got to try to keep this. So I began to really just work on things and ask more questions, and before you know it that's how that came about.

MR: I always think that the bass player has the most challenging job in the band. I mean I love the bass. And I think it was Marian McPartland who said, via Alec Wilder, "I'd kill for a good bass line." Something like that. But I've often wondered, what do you do, I read about you playing in Chicago with these fellas who would come through. And they call a tune and you don't know it. And usually the piano player is following the bass player. But if you don't know it, what do you do in that situation?

RR: Well I mean generally the pianists are the ones that — we hope one of us knows the song. But I learned when the piano players knew it and they would — a really good pianist, particularly coming from that ilk of players, the Jimmy Rowles, the Hank Jones, the Tommy Flanagans, they could lead me, if I could see their hands, they could lead me by watching. I also learned the piano a little bit more because now I started really watching so I knew the names of the notes really well. But then they would just lead me. Sometimes they would go — but eventually it was the harmonic movement that, if I really listened to it — and then I learned — "Do you know this tune?" "No." "Okay, I'll play a chorus and then you come in." The place is packed. And they don't say what key they're in, and I can't see the keyboard. So you end up growing these incredible cauliflower ears, you know, tentacles, or whatever. And I grew them by default. I had to if I was going to survive. And then I had to learn to use the intellect to say, "Oh, it's in E flat." And then he goes to something, "Oh, that must be the bridge, well where did that go? Oh, the bridge went to A flat, okay." So when it came back at least I could start and I

knew where the bridge went, at least I got the door. And then I had to retain that. So that is something that is a skill through repetition, but you have to retain it. And that's what I think the jazz musicians have sensitized those areas, to retain things that just happen. And how can you somehow develop that. And of course there are different levels of how that comes to you. I mean I could never play some of the things that John Coltrane, that we've grown to love, the "Giant Steps" and all that stuff, I mean you can't give that to someone who just can't even walk a blues. I mean they just don't hear, they have no idea. So the diet has to be digested and then expanded. But my rude awakening, because I called myself knowing a lot of tunes, standards and everything, and my very first job, real job, of playing the bass in the United States after I came back from the military, this guy was in Seattle, Washington and it was this guy, he says, "I heard you play at a jam session and I need a bass player. Can you do this gig with me?" He says, "It's six nights a week and the gig is yours. It's just me and a singer." I said yeah. And he said, "We're just playing standards, you know, 'All the Things You Are.'" And I said, "Oh I know all those songs, yeah, great." And I get there and she sings them — she sang them in the wrong keys. And there was no music. And I said, and I thought I knew these songs. Man, talking about scrambling. But eventually, that was a big lesson. That was a huge lesson. And I survived. And I got better at it. And then when I began to hear people talking about, "Well you know you should be able to play in other keys." And I said, "Yeah." But it was amazing.

MR: Is some of that, when you're talking about your ears are getting bigger and they're telling you where to go, is it also some of that like almost attached to your left hand? Like okay I hear this coming and I know that boom, that's a string down and down a position or something.

RR: Well there is a tactile association I think eventually, because, if I did this and I did this, adjusting the position, that's a whole step. So I mean, but there is a — but you can't just go by that because what if one of the strings break. So you can't all of a sudden everything fell apart. Your comfort zone, so that means you were just learning it a little bit, peripherally, it wasn't really, you didn't really hear. And that too is another way to kind of catapult you into learning something which you thought you knew. But I'm really adamant, I think my career has grown because I can retain something and then develop that. And I tell my students we have the unique ability to completely sabotage every band that we play in, immediately, if we lose the time or we hiccup with the time, or if the notes, all of a sudden you're not clear with the pitch. So that's what I mean about the clarity of the sound. The sound of a song. Not the chord changes of the song. Because Hank Jones could play the song and he would play a lot of different voicings and things, every chorus, and it would be really different, but the sound of the song was always there,

because he has so many choices that he has learned how to play and give the illusion that other things are happening. So I've had the great pleasure of being taxed and taught and embraced by all these guys that have helped me become a better player.

MR: Did that experience with the singer that time find its way into your teaching?

RR: Oh absolutely. That's where those statements come from of stop leaning on other people to make you sound good. Because that's what bass players tend to do. And most people say, "Oh I didn't know a bass could do that." Well the bass is not doing that, the bass is just a conduit of what the brain is doing, really. But people don't hear that. I mean the bass is — Ray Brown used to tell me, he says, "Well, you know, keep the bass up front. We know we're in the back, but the bass is always up front." And he says, "You be conscious of how you project your bass line." And he says, "When it's really good, if the saxophone player or the trumpet player are not really taking care of business, the listener's ears are coming right past them, because of the way that you're sounding." I said, "Really?" But we have that ability to destroy, we have that power to either make great or break the ensemble. Just like that. And so to me that's a big responsibility. And I think a lot of people don't really know that. I mean I can destroy a group better than anybody. I mean drummers think they can do that too, but everybody in the group has that ability, but I think I can do it better, because everything really resonates from the bass.

MR: That's a great statement. You can put that on your resume. You know it's such a different thing for a saxophone player, which I play. If you half know a tune you probably can get through it. You can play the melody and then you can listen to the guys do the harmony, and you can get through it. But you guys, you can't stop concentrating I guess.

RR: You can't stop. You can't stop. I mean if I stop while you were playing you'd lean around and say, "What the hell is wrong with you?" And drummers can't stop. They shouldn't stop. Why are you going to stop? So if you're not sure of what you're doing, but you still can't stop, so you've got to figure it out while you're still in motion. And the quicker you do it, everybody's happy.

MR: Did you ever wish that they would do the bass solo first, instead of all the sax players and everything, and you've been back there doing everything, and now be in the spotlight.

RR: Well one of the issues is when it gets to the bass solo then everybody just kinds of goes away and nobody's listening. There's so many jokes and I know you've heard them, you know, about to get people to start talking again just give them a bass solo. But the thing is that sometimes it's nice. Like I have an album that's coming out in the fall, and it's a big band thing of mine, but I only have one solo. And it's mine. It's mine. Just because I'm the leader of a group doesn't mean that I'm going to solo on everything. But traditionally when you're coming up, usually you have everybody playing 75 thousand choruses while

you've been supporting all that. And then there's nobody to support you when you play. And that can be a drag sometimes. And so we try to — well either I'm saying, well I don't want to solo. Because sometimes the bass solo tanks that energy that has been already established. So I don't want to do that too. If I'm going to do it, I want to help make it go too. So it's a decision sometimes, and my ego — I like to solo, I want to solo, and I think I play better solos than I used to. But most people don't hire me to take solos. Ninety-nine percent of bass players, their job is to make the band swing and feel good. So I've never developed a solo. Some people think that's all they want to do. And they actually, when they play they need a bass player to play for them. And it's different styles of concepts and things, but how I learned how to play, the soloing was just — if they let me I was lucky, if they let me play. But I never thought about it. And sometimes they let me play and I'll say no, this is not the time for a solo. And so now there are times where I've learned, well I'd like to solo on this tune. Then I can kind of orchestrate a little bit. But invariably they would always throw me towards something and it's at a tempo I can't play anyway, so I learn how to walk a solo, like Milt Hinton used to do, or some of the older players used to do. But then you'd go listen to Jimmy Blanton and he played great solos and it was long before I was even thought of, you know. So it's all subjective.

MR: Let's talk about this conference we're at. It's an interesting state of affairs in jazz it seems like. If you come here — I just came from this little gathering of people talking about research. And in that room there was at least four or five different accents of people. In other words it was like an international group of people. And you've got I don't know how many people here, and it makes jazz look really vibrant and healthy. And then you turn around and you read the typical "jazz is dead" article or — Gary Giddins said something about how can you promote this music when it's not on radio or TV etcetera.

RR: Well he just doesn't know. I don't know why or even how or why he would even make such a statement because he obviously hasn't been or doesn't see the things that I see, and see what a lot of other — it's a different time than when the music that even like what you presented with Joe Williams — that's a different era. It was a different place. And even before that, that music was really popular. I mean the pop music of that day. We've lost that. I mean even Broadway, because a lot of those songs came through Broadway musicals that the jazz musicians embraced to render, aren't even as good as they used to be. So it's not just the jazz, it's not in that sense, but there are more young people involved listening to this music in this country than ever before. Are they going to be professional musicians like myself or other people? Probably not. But there will be some that come through that just have to, they have to, they have no choice. And they'll find a way, some kind of way. Because things are different. The playing field has changed. The clubs aren't as prevalent, but sometimes the clubs — they were there but

they weren't all that — I mean nobody got rich off those clubs. They got a lot of notoriety that they could play, and you learned how to play. One of the things we're missing is a network of going from state to state, city to city, to keep the music vibrant. The airlines, the economic — whatever you want to — has made it difficult. It still costs, if Miles Davis' group was taking a flight to Paris, it costs the same for my group to go to Paris. And he's making ten or twenty thousand times more money than I'm making, because he's who he is. So the expense for people to do the same thing, or to go, it's not equitable. So we have to figure another way. Years ago, I mean when I came up, we were driving a lot in cars and vans. But things were like three or four hundred miles away and then you set up a tent for another week and then when that was finished you got back in the car and you drove a little further.

MR: You had to love it, right?

RR: Well yeah. I mean it was fantastic. It's difficult. Traveling is difficult. But I never thought about it. It's what we do. I mean when we talk about traveling now I think that's what I get paid for. I don't get paid for playing. I get paid for carrying my bass and dealing with the jerks at the airport and all the TSA and all the stuff. I mean we in this country are not happy with all the stuff for traveling, all the security. But Europe's been doing that for years, you know. And it's just part of the — but I think it's healthy in a lot of ways. I think because of the internet and because before you wanted to get famous in your town and then maybe your notoriety got to the next county and then moved, or whatever, but right now if you talk about jazz — you can't find it on the radio? If you go on the internet and you put jazz up and put radio internet it's a huge list of — and people from all over the world are listening. So we just have to, as a community, have to learn how to embrace this new thing. And some of it is more difficult than others to accept the change and to kind of go with the flow of what is happening. I didn't say it was easy, but there are people who are going to figure it out and who are figuring out how to sustain oneself. I mean players. I mean I record. Now I'm composing. I teach. And I've been doing all those things. But these are things that I love to do. I am capable of doing a lot of things. I mean when the computer came along I mean I really loved it. When it doesn't work it's a pain. But making a dollar has never been an issue for me. I mean I know how to cook, I can wash dishes. I mean I'm not going to starve. But I've learned how to play the bass and I can do things, and it's come to me to help me do, so I work at it and kept sustaining. To me, I'm not the only one that can do those things. But then most people now, you can't sit on your laurels like those things were so prevalent — I know some guys work because they were subbing for somebody else because they had so much work. And then when 9/11 happened everything just kind of came to a screeching halt, particularly in the New York area, but not just music, everything. And if you were kind of on the peripheral,

if you didn't have any clients that really trusted you and were always in your corner, eventually they'd pick you back up when things got a little — but if you were just kind of hanging on and didn't have all your own stuff, you were always depending on me to give you my extra stuff — you understand what I mean? And I think a lot of people did that profile, and they're hurting right now. Because they never had to really develop their own steam and be in control of their own stuff. And I feel very fortunate and blessed, but I've also protected, I've studied — people say, "Man, you're really lucky, you get all the gigs." I say, "That's not luck, man." I say, "I do gigs that you can't do. I do gigs you don't want to do. What are you talking about?" But if you can play with people who give you a lot and you give it back and you play, and your reputation — I mean even with the internet and it's fast as a computer can be, word of mouth is still huge. We hear the wavelength about certain people coming up, "You hear that kid, he's in Washington D.C.?" And then someone else says — they start talking about them. And then when you hear them you say, "Now I've been hearing about you." And before you know it I'll say "Well did you hear that certain —." And then it becomes really fantastic.

MR: How important is it that students learn about the parts of being a musician that aren't just the music. Punctuality and personality. As a matter of fact I think you summed it up "hanging on the bandstand" I think was your —

RR: Well, you know I really want — if the players really want it, it's here for them. There is a lot of talk about, I mean just here at the conference, there aren't a whole lot of minority kids here. So that's kind of disconcerting to a point. But like Milton Hinton, he said if a young woman wanted to play, he could care less if you are a girl, blue, green, purple. If you wanted to play and you wanted to learn something from him, it's yours. Whatever you've got is yours. And I feel the same way. The music knows no colors, has no boundaries. And I think some people dwell on that kind of stuff and you can't do that. I mean it does a disservice to everybody, particularly the music. But I want to show, when I see young people, if they're willing to listen I'm willing to work with them. Because people helped me, I mean all I needed was maybe a pat on the back and that was huge. That gave me — from someone I had a lot of respect for, or I didn't expect. Because mostly they didn't have to say anything. And if they didn't really care about you they didn't say anything. Or, "that's not really that good, you play better than that, don't do that again." They don't have to do that.

MR: Right. If they had kept quiet you'd have just kept doing it.

RR: And then eventually you fade away. So in a sense these educational things are good. We are giving a craft that students are learning a craft, but that doesn't mean that they're going to be great musicians. The music that — I mean you had a film of a character. Joe Williams was a character. I mean he was an entity. I mean he was something special. And

I think Dizzy, James Moody, Sonny Stitt, Wes Montgomery. I mean these are people that just were characters. But they had a lot of excellence. You don't have to just be a fool. You know nobody wants to be around that. And so in a sense we are not allowing the characters to come through all this, because there's a lot of cookie cutters now. There's a lot of — and it's really hard for the character to come through now, because there's probably a little more suppressed stuff for someone who wants to go this way and the masses are going over here. Because to be different, you have to be very strong.

MR: Was it, I don't know if "easier" is the right word, but for the Lester Youngs of the world, at that time, because jazz wasn't codified into books and so forth, was it easier for him to be an individual? Nowadays there's all the books to buy.

RR: I think so. And yet I don't know. He was different enough — I mean Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker, they were different enough, but even the black community didn't want to hear the stuff that they were coming up with because it was different than what they were doing or what they were used to, or it wasn't part of the church, whatever. So I think anybody who really wants to go over here is looked kind of down on. And yet, that same mass of people who are not, if they stay individual long enough, then they start saying, "Man did you know? He's really great." But it takes a long for that to settle down. And I think it's harder, more difficult now. The players are challenged more to really become an individual. And yet I think this is where people like myself, Dave Liebman and the other people who are part of this educational thing and have been for many years, believe in it. But if we're not here to kind of be like a stick in the mud and to just kind of rub and say well wait a minute. I used to be quite at odds with Jamey Aebersold, a lot. Just because I mean, well it's not wrong if I play — I mean some students, "Man I didn't play well, man, I played the wrong note in this scale. My solo sucked." And I said, "What are you talking about? You had a great solo. I thought it was really great because you had a phrase, it had feeling, it had emotion, and you have one little note out of it that you said — " give me a break. And if you don't have people like that who can kind of level somebody off and say come on, let's think about this now. And you say, "Oh, okay." Because I know some students want to please you so much and they want to be correct.

MR: Takes the life out of it.

RR: It hurts. And it takes the fun. That doesn't mean you're not serious because you're having fun. And so those are things that are prevalent now because we are so adamant about codifying everything. I never learned that way, and yet I know that — I don't know, it's an attitude. And I think if you can have balance of what's really expected, what people know and yet you can open it up and you can have this other stuff, you have the best of both worlds.

MR: If there's something that makes a person, a listener, turn his head and go oh, what was that.

RR: Right. Exactly. And the element of surprise. Matt Wilson had a wonderful workshop yesterday and I advocated also, we have such history now of playing music that is jazz, and we play the head. And then we take solos. And then we take fours. And then the drums do this. So now everybody does it that way. And then we wonder how come audiences are going to sleep. Because it's all predictable. So the element of surprise — it doesn't have to be a huge surprise, it just has to be something that's not predictable. So that's where the composition has really hit me. Because now you have to write something that somebody else who is coming out of this vein may take the composition this way. And that's what everybody expects. And all of a sudden you go — and all of a sudden people go like this — and all of a sudden you've got their attention. That's what we can do as players, as improvisers, to do something that people — they're ready for you and all of a sudden you say, "Oh, that was nice, what did they do?" But all of a sudden they did something. This is where these characters are. It was fun watching Joe Williams because when he was doing "A Child is Born" and when he said "child" his eyes got bit. I said whoa! And it was a beautiful sound coming out. You've got to have that element of surprise, to not be so one hundred percent predictable. And a lot of people don't want that.

MR: Well said. Let me run a couple of names by you and see if they strike you as, what did you learn from them or learn not to do, or anything in particular. Dexter Gordon?

RR: Wow. Powerful. Imposing. He was an imposing figure when he played it was huge. All his ideas were incredibly clear. And so I had to be clear with him at all times. And he wanted it to be powerful under him as a unit. So I had to really be strong and Eddie Gladden and I had to really work well together, and when George came in we were one. He demanded it the way he played. And when you heard it, then it became the quartet. Not four people playing at the same time, or Dexter playing and the trio was playing behind him. It was the sound of the quartet. I still reap the benefits of having been part of that group for four solid years. At that time we were traveling maybe eight months out of the year. Pretty intense. And to me, between he, Eddie Harris before he, really working, Thad Jones/Mel Lewis, two years with them, and then four years, that's really how I learned how to play, I mean really play. You didn't have a choice if you wanted to stay there.

MR: Dexter always seemed like he was a master at playing behind the beat it seemed to me.

RR: Well that was his — a lot of people thought that's the way he played because he drank a lot. But that's not it. He heard that. That's the way he played. He kind of was laid back. Because I played with him when he wasn't drinking at all. And he still played the same

way. And some people don't really believe that, but it's really true. He just heard that, the way that he phrased. And you can't write it, you can't transpose it, you just have to say, "Well just play this laid back." Well what does that mean? But he was really consistent at that. So he heard that. That wasn't something that — and the sound. It was just a full-bodied sound. I mean I've had a career with tenor players. And he was on the bottom. I mean he had this huge sound. And Stan Getz flipped it. They're almost the same age too. But Stan's voice was more in the mid-range and upper. And every once in a while he went down. But it was really interesting to me.

MR: Well you just said something that makes me think about, is there such a thing as playing on top of the beat or behind the beat?

RR: Oh absolutely. Absolutely. This is what I also work with the bass players. Because we have the pulse. This is a quarter note: one-two-three-four one-two-three-four. But that's not the pulse. The pulse is [hand gesture] and a bigger pulse is [hand gesture]. So there's a lot of things that can be done within the pulse. And the beat is actually this wide, and the center of the beat is here. Some people play over here, some people play it here, some people play it here. That's what it's like, and this zone over here. But drummers are more vivid with that. You know when I got a chance to play with Mel Lewis, he plays so, his beat was so wide that if you were a bass player and you couldn't play with Mel Lewis, something was terribly wrong. But Jack DeJohnette played more up on the beat, much more in front of the middle. But you can't measure it. I mean there is no ruler that says — but it is a feeling. Elvin Jones was really kind of more like Mel Lewis. They were really — so it was different. And as a bass player I think the rhythm section players, bass players and drummers, have to find — we have to be pliable. We have to be more like silly putty. We have to be able to compromise and find — because everybody has a different — we all have a different gait when we walk — because we're individuals. There's something a little bit different. We are all walking, and we're walking the same tempo, but we have a different gait. And so I think when we play this music, some things you can play and manage — people just float. They dance, and some people are much more stiff when they play. It's that pulse. And I think bass players and drummers have to — because that's my first job is to find and compromise with that drummer. And he or she has to do that with me. And then the piano player has no choice.

MR: Here it is, right here. You fit in.

RR: That's exactly correct. And then when the piano player comes with us, the trio, then the horn players have to come with us. They have no choice. But it becomes this huge carpet for them to just have fun. To me, that's how I think of — because I can play by myself and do whatever I want. And I can ritard and race and do this — but once you enter the picture and we're going to play a duet together and we're going to actually have

conversations, then I have to give you an opportunity to have a conversation. It's the same thing with the playing, and you come together. To me this is the magic that can not be put in a book. It can't be on page 12. It just cannot be.

MR: Yeah. And I think that's a good thing.

RR: Yes, I do too.

MR: Some of it has to come from the veterans and the players.

RR: Yes. I mean to me this is why people even like the music is the way it feels. And so when we start making everything we do be put in a book, I mean I've written a book, but there are certain things that I just can't put in a book because it's impossible. Forget about it. And some people are looking for all the answers. They're not there. And that's where we were talking about creating those characters that somehow they just have a natural feeling for it. There are people who just come to things and they just understand. They have a savvy. And they've never done it before. But somehow — you see some of these young kids that are coming up now. They play like they've been on the planet for twenty years, and they're only twelve. But they have a savvy. They just understand. We call them wunderkinds. We call them whatever. And sometimes people want to make them famous. Come on. And that to me is a drag. But they do have something. Just don't squash it you know. And that to me is why I continue to come to these conferences and things, because it's wonderful to see the hunger for some of the musicians. Because I used to be one of them.

MR: We're going to be running out of tape soon. [To Rufus' wife] Do you have any things that I should ask him?

RR: Well I do want to talk about, you weren't here, because I had my, it's actually one of my most ambitious things, the Quiet Pride, which is the music that I was commissioned to write, inspired by Elizabeth Catlett's sculptures. And that's going to come out officially hopefully in September of this year. And it's already been recorded and we're developing a game plan and a booklet. There are five movements and I have five wonderful photos of her stuff. Very exciting for me. And I got a chance to at least teach the public a little bit with a group here that went very well on Wednesday. So this is part of my compositional stuff that is starting to take hold.

MR: It's a challenge to, you almost have two abstract things if you're trying to portray a quality in a person, which is sort of abstract, and you have music which is sort of abstract.

RR: Well it's very interesting that people are saying, "Yeah it's great that art is kind of inspiring other art." And that has really become kind of neat, because my whole premise now is to go into the universities and have the jazz department, the art department, and the story of Elizabeth Catlett is pretty incredible if you come to really research and dig it. So we can go and have the Women's Studies, or Afro-American Studies, and we have

these three different disciplines kind of interacting with one another, which is unheard of sometimes. There is very little of that — going into the schools, rehearse with the band, and have the art department bring some clay and some easels and sketch, while we rehearse. Just because it's there. And then go into the sociology class and talk about her strifes and things that she had to deal with politically and racially in this country, and she still survived all that stuff you know. I mean it's a story in itself. I didn't know it was going to be like this, it's got a life of its own now. But I'm happy to say that my recording is close to where I put her art in my mind in terms of the quality of her stuff.

MR: Well best of luck with that.

RR: Thank you very much.

MR: It sounds like a natural for Hamilton College.

RR: Sounds good to me. We'll keep you in touch with that.

MR: Well it's been fascinating. I thank you for joining me today.

RR: Well thank you and of course you know our good friend Martin and JoAnn Krivin, you know they spoke about you writing the Foreword for the book.

DR: You need to talk about Martin and you.

MR: Yeah. We've got ten minutes.

[short break]

MR: You and I had a — it's very peripheral — but we had the pleasure of writing something for JoAnn Krivin's book. And I know that Martin Krivin played a big role in your life.

RR: Bigger than you can even imagine, than we even imagined. Marty Krivin, I was with Thad Jones/Mel Lewis Orchestra. And Thad was Artist-in-Residence at William Paterson University. At that time it was William Paterson College. And the two years I was with the band we would go as a quartet, out and do workshops, master classes if you will, maybe twice a semester. And this gentleman, Dr. Martin Krivin, was very observant. Because Harold Danko would talk a little bit about the piano and I would talk about the bass, and Mel would talk about the drums, etcetera, etcetera. So we would do this. And then it was November, no it was October. I get this call from Marty Krivin. "Rufus, have you seen Thad?" I said, "Excuse me?" He said, "Yeah, you know, school's started in September and I haven't been able to —" Thad had left and gone to Denmark. He was doing things with the Danish Radio Orchestra for a while, but he didn't even tell Mel Lewis that he had had enough, and he just left. So Marty said, "We've got to have somebody and I'd like you to come out." And I said, "You want me to come out? I didn't come to New York to teach. What are you talking about?" He said, "Well no, I was watching you, I really liked the way that you were conducting your portion of the workshop, just come on out and take a look. Just come on out and take a look." He was a very persuasive, real low key, but very persuasive. So I said okay. My wife said, "He's

not going to come out, we didn't come to New York for him to teach." And Marty says, "I just want him to —" you know. So I go out, and I said okay. Now I had been doing some teaching, I'll try to quickly go through this, but I enjoyed the teaching. I didn't know it, but about four years I didn't do anything but just play. So then I got there and I wasn't even thinking about teaching. But when I got out to the school I spent the whole day, and I came home and she says, "What happened?" I said, "Well it was kind of interesting, it was kind of nice." And then he said, "Well I'd like you to consider being the director of the program." And he commenced to compile everything. I had a degree from Northwestern, but he still had to compile and make people, because now when Thad left the taste in the rest of the faculty was not very nice. So I had to come in and oh now here's — another jazz guy just bolted out of here. And so I had to clean house a little bit, and Marty taught me how to deal with the academia. I says "Well I'm going to be on the road" — I was with Dexter Gordon. I said, "I'm going to be gone for two months." He says, "It's okay." I said, "What?" But he convinced — because he was building, he had visions of building a direct conduit to the marketplace with real practitioners. Yeah we had jazz people, Berklee was already going, and North Texas State with big band stuff. But not the small group. And before you know it I was there ten years and I said, "You know I've been there about six years," and she says, "You know you've been there ten years." And before you know it I was there fifteen, and I was there for twenty years. And it had given me, I didn't know what tenure was. I didn't know the difference between a music bachelor of art as opposed to a bachelor of music. I didn't know the difference. I didn't care about it. I mean I just didn't know. And then he began to show me the difference. And then when the whole New Jersey went to the university thing, then that changed, and then we got the very first, in the whole tri-state area of New York City, Connecticut and New Jersey, the first degree program of bachelor's of music in jazz studies. Now they had a jazz program at Rutgers but they didn't have a champion. Marty Krivin was my champion. He knew what he wanted. He knew how to convince the people, the powers that be, the deans, the provost, the president, and the president of the college they knew each other, they were friends, but he listened to Marty and Marty said, "We need him." And then he taught me how to — he was so great, he put a couple of my classes at the same time as the faculty meetings. So he was buffering me from all the —

MR: That's brilliant.

RR: Yeah. And I did go to faculty meetings when it was really important for me to do that, but he really protected me. He buffered me from all the other stuff. And I didn't know how much he had done until I began to go to other schools and be an artist-in-residence, and the guy said, "Man I'm so tired, I've been up all night with all my administrative stuff and I haven't been able to do this and that." And then he made it also, because our

program became really visible, he made it such that if another university was going to hire a jazz musician who had notoriety, they had to let them continue to be who they were, because that's why they wanted them. So I would tell people, I said, "Well listen, if they want you to be who you are, then they're going to have to give you some leeway to go out to travel to continue to do what you do." Now there is a price for everything. So I mean I had to kind of, I couldn't fly off just — because I was being paid, and it brought some stability into my home to the point where we were able to save enough money to send our son to the university without completely having to — my son went to Carnegie Mellon so I told him I had to charge more for quarter notes, as a bass player. But the thing was, it's an expensive school. But he chose it. I said, "Okay, you're going to have to do real well." And he did. And he's working. But the university did help us. And then I began to research — I mean the classical department musicians have been doing it for years. I mean concert pianists, cellists, violinists — they travel all over the world and they're the residents at Juilliard, or they're at Northwestern, or whatever. But all of a sudden it became a problem for a jazz musician to have to significant program at a university and still be able to do what he or she does. And I think Marty Krivin was helpful with me, and adamant about it, that other universities had to — a lot of people wanted — you have to have a doctorate in this. And there were no doctors in music. And Billy Taylor was probably it for the thirty years before anybody was a doctorate in music. But the life studies I had published, I was on a lot of recordings which were called publishing but I actually had a textbook and I had all of these things. So he actually put my portfolio so well together that it was almost a no-brainer for the school to go for it. Now I guess I was on probation, I guess this is where you have tenure and all that kind of stuff, and he helped me do all that. Because I didn't know anything about it, I didn't care less about it. I even said if some of the faculty people are really going to be kind of funky to me or not being continualized to it, because well I'm out of here. I don't need it. And so I had some great allies. And before I left, one of the best recitals was a pianist and his recital he played solo piano, he played arias and he played trios, and then he took intermission and he came back and played some jazz, and then he wrote a big band chart, and it was like, and I said that's possible. He wasn't a great jazz musician but he had a breadth. He's working now. He's always going to work. I said that's what can happen. I went to Northwestern University, you know, and they didn't talk about film scoring. They didn't talk about any of these other things that actually, at that time, when I went to school there, it was electronic music but it was really like really out kind of stuff at that time. I mean avante garde or very not tonal stuff. And jazz was, what? But that's a different day now. And so I know what can — and Marty had the vision. And he taught me that it can happen. And so that's also another reason why I enjoyed coming in

because I feel that it's important that young people see. And I propelled them. I said, "just because you can play up and down your horn and play a lot of notes, that's not enough. Never has been." But Marty Krivin, and we are thankful to him that we got a chance to know he and JoAnn, because they made our whole lives change for the better.

MR: Wow. I've been lucky to have a couple of those people too, so, I'm glad you got to speak about him.

RR: Yeah. Because we all have to survive. We all have to — but when you can find someone who really — and I never knew what that word meant — someone who champions you. Someone who really champions you. He was the one that actually, because we were the first to get – William Paterson was the first to get the Doris Duke Award. And we had Benny Golson wrote for the orchestra, and he wrote a concerto for me, and he wrote pieces for himself, and we did a thing at Alice Tully Hall with the William Chamber Orchestra. And Marty was responsible for all of it. Because he read everything, and he saw this thing. And we had everything in place that the perspectives on the grant said you had to have. And we had everything. And he applied for it, and he got it. So I mean he was an amazing man. And he was a great clarinet player. He hadn't played in a long time and when he retired he got the clarinet out and when they went up to Oneonta you know, he got a piano player and they got together.